ISLE OF CONTENTION

As Katchatheevu finds itself in the midst of a political controversy, a few facts about the barren island

- Located in the Palk Strait, Katchatheevu is no more than 1.6 km in length and slightly over 300 m wide at its broadest point
- It lies 14 nautical miles northeast of Rameswaram on the Tamil Nadu coast and 10.5 nautical miles from Delft Island in Sri Lanka
- During the British Raj, it became part of the Madras Presidency; in 1921, both India and Sri Lanka claimed Katchatheevu
- A survey marked Katchatheevu in Sri Lanka, but a British delegation from India challenged this, citing ownership of the island by the Ramnad zamindari in Tamil Nadu



CENTRE & STATE Former prime minister Indira Gandhi with former Tamil Nadu CM M. Karunanidhi

recognised Sri Lankan sovereignty over the tiny island, a subsequent 1976 agreement also recognised Indian sovereignty over Wadge Bank—a 10,000 sq. km area of the sea rich in biodiversity near Kanyakumari.

The long spell of calm ended this March. First, the BJP's Tamil Nadu unit chief K. Annamalai trotted out the allegation that the Congress government of Indira Gandhi "gave away" Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka. Based on an RTI (Right to Information) response, he was clearly trying to craft a poll plank by playing on Tamil sentiments. Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself took up the issue on March 31. In a post on X, he wrote that the Congress, which was in power at the Centre in 1974, "callously gave away" Katchatheevu. He also added that the details had "unmasked the DMK's double standards". He was alluding to the fact that the alleged ceding of the island had taken place when Tamil Nadu had a DMK chief minister, M. Karunanidhi, while subsequent DMK leaders, including current CM M.K. Stalin, have sporadically expressed concern about the island's status.

THE BJP IS AIMING TO PITCHFORK KATCHATHEEVU AS A MAJOR POLL ISSUE, ESPECIALLY TO PUT I.N.D.I.A. PARTNERS DMK AND THE CONGRESS ON THE MAT

On April 1, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar waded into the controversy, saying both former premiers Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira had dubbed Katchatheevu as "little island" and "little rock" and were ready to relinquish claims on it. The DMK had "connived" with Indira on the issue, he alleged, adding that Sri Lanka has detained 6,184 Indian fishermen in the past 20 years. Clearly, the BJP is aiming to pitchfork Katchatheevu as a major electoral issue, especially to put I.N.D.I.A. bloc partners DMK and Congress in a tight spot, given that the 1974 agreement was made during their governance.

However, the response from the Congress—all of them on X—was swift. Congress leader Manish Tewari was blunt: "You have to be first class knucklehead to believe that the lady who cleaved Pakistan into two, redrew the geographical map of South Asia in 1971...created Bangladesh—Late Prime Minister Indira Gandhi would give up Katchatheevu Island to Sri Lanka under any duress, coercion or compulsion." In a point-by-point rebuttal, party spokesman Jairam Ramesh reminded the PM that in 1974 itself, the Bandaranaike-Indira pact had allowed the repatriation of 600,000 Tamils from Sri Lanka to India. "In a single move, PM Indira Gandhi secured human rights and dignity for six lakhs hitherto stateless people," he posted.

Senior Congress leader P. Chidambaram said while it is true that Indian fishermen were detained, India, too, has detained many Lankan fishermen. "Every government has negotiated with Sri Lanka and freed our fishermen. This happened when Mr Jaishankar was a foreign service officer and when he was Foreign Secretary and when he was Foreign Minister. Were not fishermen detained by Sri Lanka when Mr Vajpayee was PM.... Were not fishermen detained by Sri Lanka when Mr Modi was in power since 2014?" he wrote.

Under the 1974 agreement, Indian fishermen could dry their nets in Katchatheevu. However, they are not allowed to fish near the island—a fact that has been a sticking point in Tamil Nadu. The issue of Indian fishermen being arrested by the Lankan Navy for "illegal poaching" in its maritime waters—around 150 have been detained this year alone—and their trawlers being impounded has been an extremely emotive issue in Tamil Nadu and a